

ENG 101

Lesson -26

In a correctly written sentence, the subject and verb **agree** i.e. **match** in number. In other words a singular subject will take a singular verb and plural subjects will take plural verbs. Most students have no problem handling a simple sentence where its not difficult to make the subject and verb agree or match. e.g.

- *My mother works at two jobs. My grandma takes care of my brothers and sisters.*

No all sentences are so straight forward.

- *Last night, I played chess. My friends played card.*

Singular Plural

work You work

You work We work

He works They work

She works

It works

1. The rag picker (sort, sorts) huge bundles of rags.
2. The rage pickers (sort, sorts) huge bundles of rags.
3. The student (listen, listens) to music while studying
4. The students (listen, listens) to music while studying.
5. The worm (wiggle, wriggles) in the glass tube.
6. The worms (wiggle, wriggles) in the glass tube.
7. The gardener (whistle, whistles) while watering plants.
8. The gardeners (whistle, whistles) while watering plants.

S

V

Most shops on Mall Road, are having sales this week.

1. *One of my best friends now lives / live in Dubai.*
2. *The wafer in this ice cream taste / tastes like sawdust.*
3. *Many people in the Indo-Pak subcontinent speaks / speak several languages.*
4. *No person in my class sleep / sleeps through my lecture.*
5. *The toddler by the swings is / are my nephew.*

Verb Coming Before The Subject

I (saw) the film.

The plate (dropped) from her hands.

A plane (crashed)

- i. What was the result of the cricket match?
- ii. There are many unemployed teachers in the district.
- iii. Here is the computer disk of the lesson.
- iv. In that box are other photographs.
- v. What was the purpose of that lecture?

Practice 3. Identify the subject and verb in each sentence.

- i. Where is / are the keys of the cupboard?
- ii. Underneath the big stone live / lives many colonies of ants.
- iii. In my back garden grow / grows many herbs.
- iv. Why does / do you always have to be right?
- v. Here is /are some cards for you.

Each	anyone	anybody	anything
Either	everyone	everybody	everything
Neither	someone	somebody	something
One	no one	nobody	nothing

The pronouns in the above box are always singular.

1. They always take singular verbs.

Note the subject-verb relationships in the following sentences with indefinite pronouns subject. e.gs.

- i. One of those correspondence courses is still open.
- ii. Neither of my parents is alive.
- iii. Somebody was opening my letters
- iv. Nearly everyone in my class owns a computer.

Practice 4.

Identify the subject and the verb that agrees with it.

- i. 'Everything in this crate goes / go upstairs', she said.
- ii. Neither of the phones works / work.
- iii. No one favors / favor a cheat.

iv. Each of the appear / appears to have been nibbled by the same person.

v. Something about her story sound / sounds suspicious.

Compound Subjects. The fourth and the last type of situation which can pose problems in subject-verb agreement are compound subjects.

1- **Compound Subjects** - usually two or more subjects which are joined by *and*, they require a plural verb. e.g.s.

i. Petrol and car repairs are my biggest expenses every month.

ii. There were VCRs and Cameras for rent.

iii. Crockery and cutlery items are included in the bill.

2- When compound subjects are joined by *or*, *nor*, *either...or*, *neither...nor*, *not only... but also*, the verb agrees with the closer subject. e.g.

-Either grapes or mango ice cream is the specialty every Saturday at the students dining hall.

-Either mango ice cream or grapes are the specialty every Saturday at the students dining hall.

3- While most indefinite pronouns such as *each*, *everyone*, *one* *somebody* etc.. are always singular, there are a few pronouns that are not. The pronouns ***both*** and ***a few*** are always plural and require plural verbs.

e.g - Both of my aunts play the sitar and sing professionally.

A few of my cousins are also actors

4. The pronouns **all** and **some** are either singular or plural depending on the words that follow them. If the words after them are singular, then they are singular. If the words after plural, then they are plural e.g. -*Some of the chicken is still on the table.*

-*Some of the guests are not having chicken.*

Practice 5. Identify the verb given in brackets that agrees with the compound subjects.

i Our aunts and uncles (stay / stays) with us when they come to Lahore.

- ii. (Is / are) the actor and actresses ready to take the curtain call?
- iii. Ropes and a clamp (holds / hold) the mural.
- iv. The broken head lights and side light (was / were) the result of my bad driving.
- v. The batsmen and the wicket keeper (require / requires) a fitness certificate.
- vi. All of the students at the lecture (was / were) glad when it was over.
- vii. Eitehr Jameela or her daughter (stay / stays) at home to take care of Iqbal.
- viii. Neither the head clerk nor his assistant clerks (has been / have been) fired for corruption.
- ix. Not only Khalid but also his friends (is / are) to blame for the accident.
- x. A few of the strawberries (tastes / taste) funny.

Test

Each of the following passages contains two mistakes in subject-verb agreement. Find these mistakes and correct them.

- i. The rain forests of Brazil is home to many species of frogs. Nobody among the world's scientists know exactly how many. More types are being discovered all the time.
- ii. The paint on the house and garage are peeling. Also each of the buildings need repairs. However, there is never enough time to do those jobs.
- iii. One of our professors always listens to students and makes sure they understand the lecture. Each of his students feel free to ask questions. Also the tests in his classes is always fair and clear.

Review:

Fill in the correct words in each space.

- 1. A singular subject takes a _____ verb. (singular / plural).
- 2. A plural subject takes a _____ verb. (singular / plural)

3. The (singular or plural) _____ of present tense verbs is sometimes formed by adding the letter s to the end of the verb.

4. The subject of a sentence is often found in a prepositional phrase. (T / F) _____.

5. Compound subjects require a plural verb. (T / F)

_____.

6. The indefinite pronouns **anyone** and **everybody** take a _____ verb. (singular / plural)

7. The pronouns both and few are always plural and require plural verbs. (T / F) _____.